
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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1

Donnarumma breathes a sigh of relief

For [Manchester City](#), Gianluigi Donnarumma has always been a case of risk and reward. Perhaps only Thibaut Courtois is as fine a shot-stopper as Italy's Euro 2020 hero, though many goalkeepers are better with the ball at their feet. Claudio Bravo, let alone Ederson, would be unlikely to dither in the fashion that alerted Kai Havertz to the possibility of pressing City's keeper as close as possible for Arsenal's goal. Donnarumma was the signing who bucked the Pep Guardiola doctrines, and his goalkeeping has been crucial to City's revival but such mistakes have always been part of the giant Italian's makeup. Paris Saint-Germain would not meet his wage demands, and opted for Lille's Lucas Chevalier, a better ball-player as an ill-starred replacement. Donnarumma smothered a good chance for Havertz in the second half. His big mistake, seconds after Rayan Cherki's opener, did not, after all, become the key twist in the title race. **John Brewin**

2

Jones slots in nicely at right-back

It was an indication of Liverpool's evolution over the course of this season that the central midfielder Curtis Jones started the Merseyside derby at right-back, while summer recruit Jeremie Frimpong was left on the bench. Jones has played in the position before and produced an accomplished display. His calm nature makes him suited to the role; he read the danger instinctively and faced up against Everton's trickiest attacking player, Iliman Ndiaye, without being intimidated. When [Liverpool](#) were in possession, Arne Slot gave permission for Jones to move into more familiar territory, shifting into the centre of the park where he could receive the ball and try to create overloads. There was never a chance he would look to overlap Mohamed Salah, something Frimpong takes great pride in. Jones is the more conservative option at full-back, a trait Liverpool require as they look to grind their way to Champions League qualification. **Will Unwin**

3

De Zerbi puts faith in Simons to save Spurs

To stand any chance of avoiding relegation, Tottenham will need Xavi Simons to put in the kind of performance he managed against Brighton on Saturday. The Netherlands attacker has struggled for consistency since joining last summer – hardly a surprise given that he has played under three different managers in his first [Premier League](#) season. Simons set up Pedro Porro's opener before scoring a brilliant goal that looked like being the winner until Georginio Rutter's late strike. Roberto De Zerbi praised Simons' efforts and thinks he can unlock more from the 22-year-old, as Spurs

prepare for five games that will determine their destiny. "He needs to feel confidence from the manager. And I stay here to transfer all the confidence he needs," said the Italian. "Because [when] I was a player, I was No 10, and I think I know what he thinks. I think I'm lucky to have this player on my team, but also he's lucky because with No 10, I can understand better than other coaches." **Ed Aarons**

Heaven shines brighter than Garnacho

At a reported compensation cost of £1m-£1.5m, the signing of Ayden Heaven is the type of deal Chelsea's brains trust would love to pull off. Think of the resale value. Those not yet in the grip of placing dollar signs against everything could celebrate Heaven's performance in leading Manchester United's rearguard effort at Stamford Bridge, and the promise of more to come in a red shirt. Similar expectations were once held in Alejandro Garnacho who, after arriving as a first-half sub for Estevão, showed United what they have not missed. Successive United managers were exasperated that the Argentinian's attacking talents were not balanced by dedicated work off the ball. Liam Rosenior will have similar thoughts on Garnacho's role in allowing Bruno Fernandes to breeze past and supply Matheus Cunha for United's goal. Rosenior may not be suitable for his position but like his predecessors under the BlueCo regime, he must work with players bought as assets rather than footballers. Garnacho cost £40m. Think of the resale value. **JB**

Eddie Howe's biggest problem is not Newcastle's dismal results – although eight defeats in 11 Premier League games remains damning – but last summer's £220m transfer market spend. Given Newcastle's manager has a much bigger say on signings than most of his Premier League peers, he is largely culpable for blowing the £125m gained from Alexander Isak's sale on Nick Woltemade, Yoane Wissa, Anthony Elanga and Jacob Ramsey. As [Bournemouth](#) won 2-1 on Tyneside, with the outstanding Alex Scott running midfield, Elanga and Ramsey were alarmingly poor before being withdrawn. Woltemade stepped off the substitutes' bench for the last few minutes and Wissa stayed on it. Afterwards Howe admitted he struggles to accommodate the £69m Woltemade's unique skills in his 4-3-3 system. It all contrasted unfavourably with Bournemouth where, despite losing a raft of leading players last summer, shrewd recruitment has left Andoni Iraola's side challenging for Europe. Tellingly the scorer of the winning goal, the left-back Adrien Truffert, arrived from Rennes for a bargain initial £11.4m last summer. **Louise Taylor**

Should Burnley stick with Parker?

The end is nigh for [Burnley](#) as they prepare to return to the Championship, and the manager's position is bound to come under scrutiny again as Scott Parker approaches the final year of his contract. Despite spending last season in the second tier, only five teams have endured more than Burnley's 45 defeats from 71 Premier League games over the past three years. The last time they went down, Vincent Kompany departed for Bayern Munich, and they're not doing too badly. Is it the manager's responsibility for a mid-sized club like Burnley yo-yoing between the two divisions? Parker led them to promotion before; perhaps he should be offered another chance. **Peter Lansley**

Arsenal lacking killer instinct

Now for the run-in, where [Arsenal](#) somehow have to recover ebbing confidence. Mikel Arteta's formula for success was going so well. And now it no longer is. Those scenes of Kai Havertz's missed header being followed by Arsenal's manager hitting the deck in agony may come to define another near-miss of a season. Not enough chances of that quality were created by Arteta's team, severely lacking in creativity in the absence of Bukayo Saka and with Martin Ødegaard a reduced force. What appeared a bold, attacking selection did not match the verve of City players such as Rayan Cherki and Nico O'Reilly or the doggedness of Bernardo Silva. When it came time for expression, assuming responsibility, grasping the nettle, a team drilled by a prescriptive coach could not find the necessary inspiration and killer instinct. With a Champions League semi-final to come and five more Premier League matches, the "fire" Arteta declares is within him and his team must be relocated. **JB**

Farke deserving of more love

Leeds are not mathematically safe yet but, after Tottenham's draw with Brighton on Saturday evening, there is now an eight-point buffer between Daniel Farke's men and the relegation zone. Which raises the question: does Farke deserve a little bit more credit than he gets? He has not only guided Leeds back to the Premier League but barring an extraordinary sequence of results – 39 points has been enough to survive in each of the past eight seasons – he has kept them there too, as well as taking them to a first FA Cup semi-final since 1987. There's often murmurings of discontent on the Elland Road terraces about whether Farke is the right man for the club. If, as now expected, he takes them into a second successive Premier League campaign, there is perhaps a conversation to talk about him in a more positive light. **Aaron Bower**

Abraham proves his worth with key goals

Tammy Abraham is still only 28 but he returned to England in January as a largely forgotten figure; certainly nobody is tipping him to be in Thomas Tuchel's England squad. His previous loan spell at Villa was in 2018-19, when he scored 25 league goals to inspire promotion via the playoffs. He has been nowhere near as prolific this time round, but he has played his role perfectly, coming off the bench and scoring two vital late goals: an equaliser at home to Leeds and Sunday's winner against [Sunderland](#). Without those four points, Villa might not look quite so secure in the Champions League qualifying slots. The question, then, is whether Villa sign the striker from Besiktas on a permanent basis. That may depend on whether they can afford him, which in turn may be dependent on Champions League qualification. Abraham is doing his bit to ensure that happens.

Jonathan Wilson

It finished goalless in this west London derby but only [Brentford](#) looked capable of nicking it at the close. Marco Silva wanted his Fulham side to attack, too, bringing on Oscar Bobb, Josh King and Raul Jiménez in the second half. "We wanted to win the game, we needed to win the game and it was a moment to take that type of risk," said Silva. Yet his side failed to test Caoimhín Kelleher all game, with Fulham's substitutes unable to change the tune. An injury to Alex Iwobi added to Silva's frustrations, as did Harry Wilson's failure to hit the target when he found space in the area. Fulham remain in that tight mid-table pack, European football still on offer – but it's time to work on those shooting drills, for someone to help out Wilson, their headliner this season. They've now failed to score in five games out of six. **Taha Hashim**

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	33	37	70
2	Man City	32	36	67
3	Man Utd	33	13	58
4	Aston Villa	33	6	58
5	Liverpool	33	11	55
6	Chelsea	33	11	48
7	Brentford	33	4	48
8	AFC Bournemouth	33	0	48
9	Brighton	33	6	47
10	Everton	33	1	47
11	Sunderland	33	-4	46
12	Fulham	33	-3	45
13	Crystal Palace	31	-1	42
14	Newcastle	33	-3	42
15	Leeds	33	-7	39
16	Nottm Forest	33	-9	36
17	West Ham	32	-17	32
18	Tottenham Hotspur	33	-11	31
19	Burnley	33	-33	20
20	Wolverhampton	33	-37	17

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